in Zimbabwe offer higher standards than in their parent companies back home.

Nevertheless the dominance of South African companies in Zimbabwe's platinum sector, especially Implats/Zimplats, reflects South African economic hegemony in Zimbabwe. Until a recent ban on the export of raw platinum, Zimbabwe exported raw ore to South Africa where it was refined. This means South Africa has always had the lion's share of Zimbabwe's platinum by value, and helps explain why SA companies dominate mining.

India

India's investments in Zimbabwe's mining sector have enormous potential, but so far have been hindered by politics. Essar, an Indian global company, emerged as the preferred bidder for Zimbabwe Iron and Steel Company (ZISCO) in 2011 after an international tender had been issued by government. It set up New Zim Steel to revive the steel-making capacity at the currently non-functional ZISCO plant and New Zim Minerals, which would explore beneficiation of iron ore that is owned by ZISCO Steel and create value so that the country becomes a world leader in beneficiated iron ore.

Two years on, operations have not started due to myriad challenges, chief of which is the rights to an estimated US$60 billion worth of iron ore reserves in Chivhu. Essar's Resident Director for Africa, Middle East and Turkey, Firdhose Coovadia, admits, 'Yes there are challenges, in our particular case bear in mind we are dealing with a national asset, it's an emotive asset.'

Another company, India's state-owned National Mineral Development Corporation (NMDC), is reported to have signed a Memorandum of Understanding with a Zimbabwean company, Mosi-oa-Tunya Development Company (MtDC). The MoU paves the way for the formation of a 50/50 joint venture company that will undertake diamond, gold, chrome and iron-ore exploration and mining in Zimbabwe. NMDC, listed on the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE), is India's largest iron-ore producer. The Mosi-oa-Tunya Development Company is reported to be a special-purpose vehicle under the administrative control of Walter Mzembi's Tourism ministry. It is perplexing why a parastatal under the Ministry of Tourism is signing MoUs for mining deals when this is the prerogative of the Zimbabwe Mining Development Corporation. This is the sort of shady dealing which greatly undermines the long-term investment potential of relationships with BRICS corporations and countries. There is a need to clearly define the functions of all ministries and departments to avoid confusion and corruption in the operations of government.